elected to focus on his academic career. He's now a visiting assistant professor at another American university – but he's definitely one of the good guys and I will always value his support and his friendship.

The guy who brought us the material on Julius Baer, Rudolf Elmer, wished to be outed, and he was fined €7,500. He then said he wanted to call a press conference at which he could be seen handing over to me two CDs full of data about the bank. We did the press conference, and it seems it might bring him further trouble, but who's to say what was on the CDs? You can't prosecute a person for handing another person a couple of blank CDs, unless you can prove there was something on them. Deniability is not just a word, it's a way of life and a programme for us. We had faced big threats before, not least from the Church of Scientology. And we always seek to reward our torturers with further revelations.

Lawyers often behave like thieves, especially the good ones. And legal action has proved a blunt instrument with which to dissect WikiLeaks. We are designed like the many-headed Hydra: you cut off one of our heads and another one pops up elsewhere. This only reflects the irrepressible nature of people's appetite for the truth, and my own liking for a scrap. There would be court cases that seemed to me terribly sinister, the kind one would relish neither fighting nor winning – one can never relish losing – but the majority of those who sought legal injunction against the activities of WikiLeaks can best be understood with reference to King Canute. He ordered the waves to go back and they ignored him, wetting his feet.

Occasionally, though, you see how legal action has simply scared a good moral cause out of its wits at the first post. Late in 2008, we became aware that eight *Guardian* and *Observer* stories on Nadhmi Auchi, an Iraqi-British billionaire whose bank, BNP Paribas, was the sole financial institution receiving billions in 'oil-for-food' programme money during the regime of Saddam Hussein, had been pulled from their website. Auchi has been the subject of a 2004 Pentagon Inspector General's report into mobile telecommunication licences. And before that, in 2003, he had been extradited from the UK to France and convicted over multi-million-dollar kickbacks on Kuwaiti government asset sales. Martin Bright, a reporter on the *New Statesman*, had, in 2008, drawn attention to the fact that the *Guardian/Observer* had bowed to legal pressure from Auchi: '[They had] been forced to pull down six articles about Nadhmi Auchi, the Iraqi businessman convicted of fraud in France in 2003. Auchi has been on the